General Purpose Input Output

Introduction to ARM Cortex-M Microprocessors — Chapter 8

Muním Zabidi

Faculty of Electrical Engineering, Universiti Teknologi Malaysia

Table of Contents

1. Why This Matters
2. Inside a GPIO Pin
3. The GPIO Registers
4. Experiments
5. Addendum

Why This Chapter Matters

Chapter 4 blinked an LED in C. Chapters 5–7 showed what that program became: load, mask, store, branch. This chapter closes the loop. The same `MODER`/`ODR` pattern is the base of every peripheral in this book. A GPIO pin is the simplest bridge between software and the physical world.

After this chapter, you can:

1. Describe the parts of a GPIO pin.
2. Choose push-pull or open-drain for a circuit.
3. Configure mode, type, speed and pulls.
4. Explain why the peripheral clock comes first.
5. Use `BSRR` for atomic pin changes.
6. Read a switch reliably, with debouncing.
7. Drive a display from a lookup table.

© Muním Zabidi

Table of Contents

1 Why This Matters

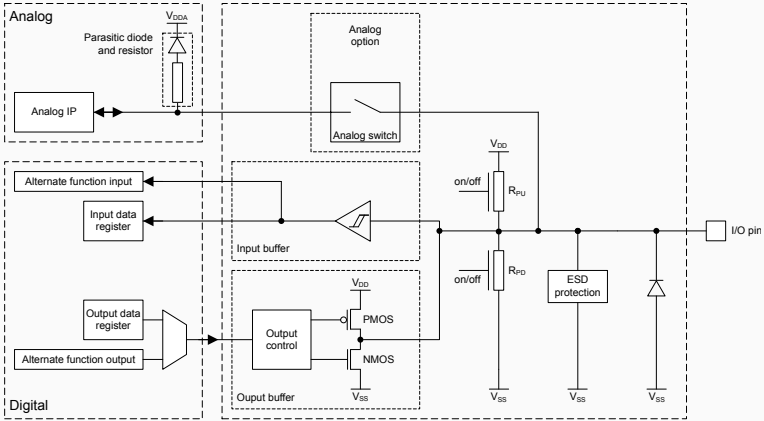
2 **Inside a GPIO Pin**

3 The GPIO Registers

4 Experiments

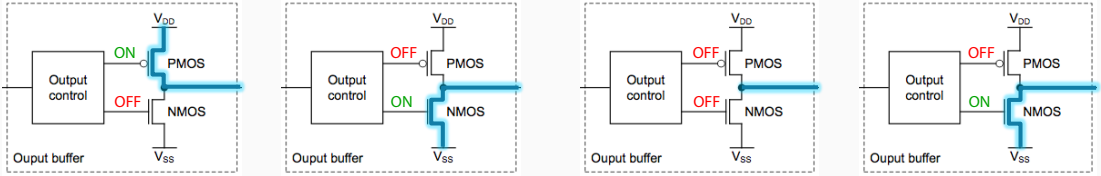
5 Addendum

Inside a GPIO Pin



One pin has two separate paths: an input path through a Schmitt trigger to `IDR`, and an output path from `ODR` through the driver transistors. Pull resistors sit in between.

Push-Pull and Open-Drain



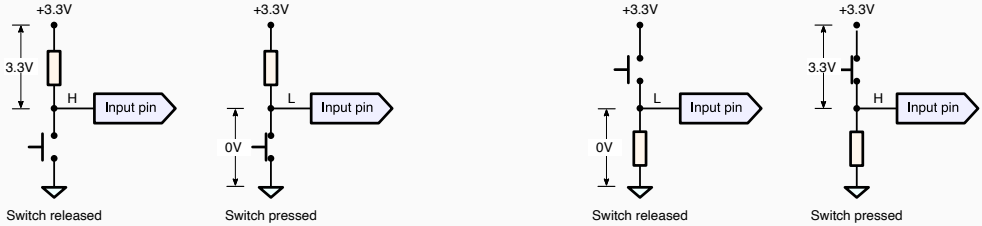
Push-pull — drives both high and low

Open-drain — pulls low, or releases

When you need open-drain

Push-pull is the default. It is what you want for an LED. But if two devices share one wire, one driving high while the other drives low causes a short circuit. Open-drain lets many devices share one line safely. This is exactly how I^2C works (Chapter 13).

Pull-Up and Pull-Down

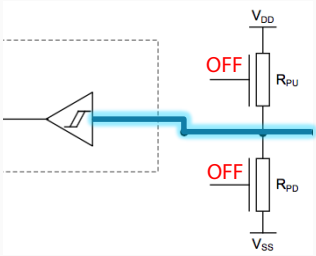


An unconnected input *floats*

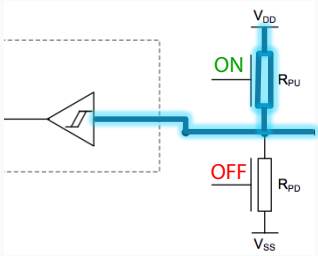
It picks up noise and reads a random value. A pull resistor gives it a fixed level when nothing else is driving it.

A button wired to ground needs a pull-up, so pressed reads 0. This is called active-low. PUPDR can turn on a pull-up inside the chip, so you do not need an extra part.

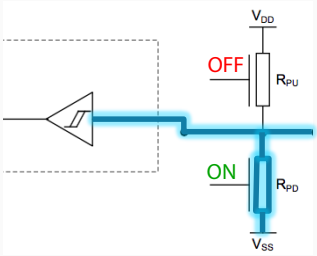
PUPDR — The Internal Resistors



Floating



Pulled up



Pulled down

Two bits per pin: `00` floating, `01` pull-up, `10` pull-down. An internal resistor means one fewer part on the board. This is Chapter 1's cost argument again.

Table of Contents

1 Why This Matters

2 Inside a GPIO Pin

3 **The GPIO Registers**

4 Experiments

5 Addendum

The Register Set

Register	Bits/pin	Purpose
`MODER`	2	Mode: input, output, alternate function, analog
`OTYPER`	1	Output type: push-pull or open-drain
`OSPEEDR`	2	Output slew rate
`PUPDR`	2	Pull-up, pull-down, or neither
`IDR`	1	Input data — read the pin
`ODR`	1	Output data — drive the pin
`BSRR`	2	Atomic bit set / reset
`AFR[2]`	4	Which alternate function (Chapter 10)

Bits per pin tells you how to build the mask

One bit wide: mask `1`, at position n. Two bits wide: mask `3`, at position $2n$. Four bits wide: mask `0xF`, at position $4n$.

© Muním Zabidi

MODER — Selecting the Mode

31	30	29	28	27	26	25	24	23	22	21	20	19	18	17	16
MODER15[1:0]		MODER14[1:0]		MODER13[1:0]		MODER12[1:0]		MODER11[1:0]		MODER10[1:0]		MODER9[1:0]		MODER8[1:0]	
rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw
15	14	13	12	11	10	9	8	7	6	5	4	3	2	1	0
MODER7[1:0]		MODER6[1:0]		MODER5[1:0]		MODER4[1:0]		MODER3[1:0]		MODER2[1:0]		MODER1[1:0]		MODER0[1:0]	
rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw

Bits	Mode
00	Input (reset state)
01	General-purpose output
10	Alternate function
11	Analog

```
GPIOA->MODER &= ~(3U « (5*2));  // clear
GPIOA->MODER |=  (1U « (5*2));  // set 01
```

Clear first, then set. Without the clear step, you cannot change a `11` into a `01`.

BSRR — Atomic Set and Reset

31	30	29	28	27	26	25	24	23	22	21	20	19	18	17	16
BR15	BR14	BR13	BR12	BR11	BR10	BR9	BR8	BR7	BR6	BR5	BR4	BR3	BR2	BR1	BR0
w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w
15	14	13	12	11	10	9	8	7	6	5	4	3	2	1	0
BS15	BS14	BS13	BS12	BS11	BS10	BS9	BS8	BS7	BS6	BS5	BS4	BS3	BS2	BS1	BS0
w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w	w

`ODR |= x` is a read-modify-write: three separate steps. If an interrupt changes another pin in between, that change is lost.

```
GPIOA->BSRR = (1U « 5);       // PA5 on
GPIOA->BSRR = (1U « (5+16)); // PA5 off
```

One write, no read. Note the = instead of `|=`. Using `|=` here would be a bug.

Peripheral Clock Gating

31	30	29	28	27	26	25	24	23	22	21	20	19	18	17	16
Res.	OTGHS ULPIEN	OTGHS EN	Res.	Res.	Res.	Res.	Res.	Res.	DMA2 EN	DMA1 EN	Res.	Res.	BKP SRAMEN	Res.	Res.
	rw	rw							rw	rw			rw		

15	14	13	12	11	10	9	8	7	6	5	4	3	2	1	0
Res.	Res.	Res.	CRC EN	Res.	Res.	Res.	Res.	GPIOH EN	GPIOG EN	GPIOF EN	GPIOE EN	GPIOD EN	GPIOC EN	GPIOB EN	GPIOA EN
			rw					rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw	rw

The classic first bug

Every peripheral starts with its clock disabled, to save power. A peripheral with no clock does not respond to writes: the writes are simply lost. No fault, no error, nothing happens.

```
RCC->AHB1ENR |= (1U « 0);  // GPIOA
```

Table of Contents

1 Why This Matters

2 Inside a GPIO Pin

3 The GPIO Registers

4 **Experiments**

5 Addendum

With ODR

```
#include "stm32f4xx.h"
void delay_ms(uint32_t ms) { for (uint32_t i=0;i<ms*4000;i++)
       __NOP(); }
int main(void) {
    RCC->AHB1ENR |= (1U << 0);
    GPIOA->MODER &= ~(3U << 10);
    GPIOA->MODER |=  (1U << 10);
    while (1) {
        GPIOA->ODR |=  (1U << 5);
        delay_ms(500);
        GPIOA->ODR &= ~(1U << 5);
        delay_ms(500);
    }
}
```

With BSRR

```
#include "stm32f4xx.h"
void delay_ms(uint32_t ms) { for (uint32_t i=0;i<ms
      *4000;i++) __NOP(); }
int main(void) {
    RCC->AHB1ENR |= (1U << 0);
    GPIOA->MODER &= ~(3U << 10);
    GPIOA->MODER |=  (1U << 10);
    while (1) {
        GPIOA->BSRR = (1U << 5);
        delay_ms(500);
        GPIOA->BSRR = (1U << 21);
        delay_ms(500);
    }
}
```

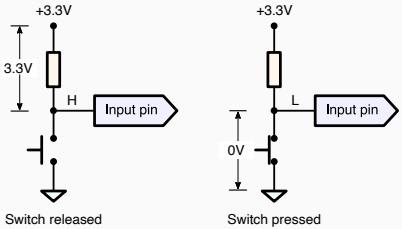
Same effect, but the second version is atomic and one instruction shorter.

$5 \times 2 = 10$, so PA5's mode bits sit at position 10. $5 + 16 = 21$ is its reset bit in BSRR.

Experiment 3: Button Controls LED

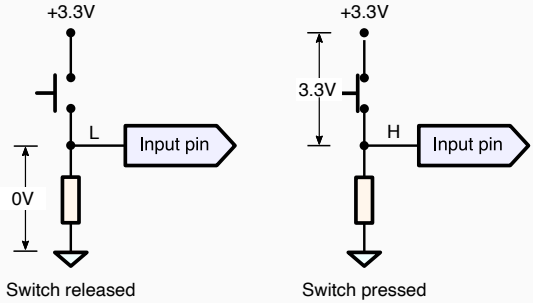
```c
#include "stm32f4xx.h"
int main(void) {
    RCC->AHB1ENR |= (1U << 2) | (1U << 0);  // GPIOC, GPIOA
    GPIOA->MODER &= ~(3U << 10);
    GPIOA->MODER |=  (1U << 10);        // PA5 output (LED)
    GPIOC->MODER &= ~(3U << (13*2));    // PC13 input
    GPIOC->PUPDR &= ~(3U << (13*2));
    GPIOC->PUPDR |=  (1U << (13*2));    // pull-up

    while (1) {
        if (!(GPIOC->IDR & (1U << 13))) {
            GPIOA->BSRR = (1U << 5);        // pressed -> on
        } else {
            GPIOA->BSRR = (1U << (5+16));   // released -> off
        }
    }
}
```



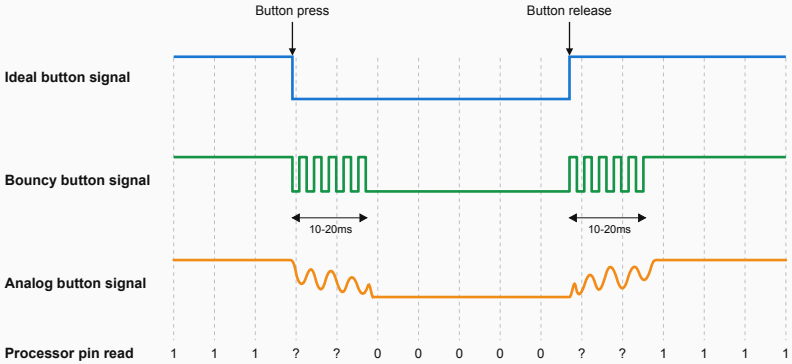
The button is active low: pressed reads `0`. When released, the ~40 kΩ pull-up holds the pin HIGH. When pressed, the switch gives a low-resistance path to ground. That path wins.

The Other Convention: Pull-Down



A pull-down with an active-high switch is the mirror image: released reads LOW, and pressed connects the pin to V_{DD}. Use `PUPDR = 10` instead of `01`, and change the polarity in the code to match.

Experiment 4: Why a Button Needs Debouncing



A mechanical contact does not close cleanly. It bounces for several milliseconds. A processor that polls at MHz speed sees one press as dozens.

Debouncing

```c
#include "stm32f4xx.h"
void delay_ms(uint32_t ms) { for (uint32_t i=0;i<ms*4000;i++)
      __NOP(); }
void handle_press(void) { /* app-specific action */ }

int main(void) {
    RCC->AHB1ENR |= (1U << 2);         // GPIOC clock
    GPIOC->MODER &= ~(3U << (13*2));  // PC13 input
    GPIOC->PUPDR &= ~(3U << (13*2));
    GPIOC->PUPDR |=  (1U << (13*2));  // pull-up

    while (1) {
        if ((GPIOC->IDR & (1U << 13)) == 0) {
            delay_ms(20);              // let it settle
            if ((GPIOC->IDR & (1U << 13)) == 0) {
                // a real press
                while ((GPIOC->IDR & (1U << 13)) == 0)
                    ;                  // wait for release
                handle_press();
            }
        }
    }
}
```

Mind the brackets

In C, `&` binds *looser* than `==`. So `IDR & (1«13) == 0` is parsed as `IDR & ((1«13) == 0)`, which is always zero.

Always put brackets around the mask.

A 20 ms delay is the usual choice. It is long enough for a mechanical switch to settle, and short enough that a user does not notice.

Experiment 5: Four-Bit Binary Counter

Four LEDs on PB0–PB3 display a counter. Directly connects this chapter to your digital-electronics course.

```c
#include "stm32f4xx.h"
void delay_ms(uint32_t ms) { for (uint32_t i=0; i<ms*4000; i++) __NOP(); }

int main(void) {
    RCC->AHB1ENR |= (1U << 1);        // enable GPIOB clock
    GPIOB->MODER &= ~(0xFFU);         // clear PB0..PB3 (two bits each)
    GPIOB->MODER |=  (0x55U);         // PB0..PB3 as outputs

    uint8_t count = 0;
    while (1) {
        GPIOB->ODR = (GPIOB->ODR & ~0xFU) | (count & 0xFU);
        count++;
        delay_ms(300);
    }
}
```

Why the mask-and-write

`GPIOB->ODR` controls all 16 pins. The expression `(ODR & ~0xF) | (count & 0xF)` clears the low nibble and writes the new value there, leaving the other 12 pins untouched.

Experiment 6: Measuring Reaction Time

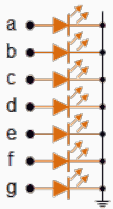
```c
#include "stm32f4xx.h"
void delay_ms(uint32_t ms) { for (uint32_t i=0;i<ms*4000;i++) __NOP(); }
volatile uint32_t reaction_ms;      // inspect this in the debugger
int main(void) {
    RCC->AHB1ENR |= (1U << 0) | (1U << 2);  // GPIOA, GPIOC
    GPIOA->MODER &= ~(3U << 10);
    GPIOA->MODER |=  (1U << 10);            // PA5 output (LED)
    GPIOC->MODER &= ~(3U << (13*2));        // PC13 input (button)
    GPIOC->PUPDR &= ~(3U << (13*2));
    GPIOC->PUPDR |=  (1U << (13*2));        // pull-up

    while (1) {
        GPIOA->BSRR = (1U << (5+16));   // LED off
        delay_ms(2000);                 // wait before the cue
        GPIOA->BSRR = (1U << 5);        // LED on: react now

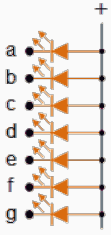
        reaction_ms = 0;
        while (GPIOC->IDR & (1U << 13)) {   // until the button goes LOW
            delay_ms(1);
            reaction_ms++;
        }
        GPIOA->BSRR = (1U << (5+16));   // acknowledge
        delay_ms(1000);
    }
}
```

This measurement is only as accurate as `delay_ms`, a calibrated software loop. Its timing shifts with compiler optimization and clock speed. A hardware counter would make it exact.

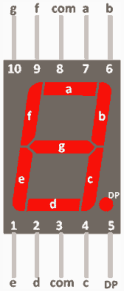
Experiment 7: A Seven-Segment Display



Common Cathode



Common Anode





Use a lookup table, not per-segment logic

Deciding which of seven segments to light for each digit is a table, not an algorithm. One array indexed by the digit replaces a whole page of `if` statements. It is also faster and easier to check.

Common-Anode Lookup Table

```c
#include "stm32f4xx.h"
void delay_ms(uint32_t ms) { for (uint32_t i=0;i<ms*4000;i++) __NOP()
      ; }

// common-anode codes, digits 0-9
// bit0=a ... bit6=g, bit7=dp -- 0 lights the segment
static const uint8_t seg7_ca[10] = {
    0xC0, 0xF9, 0xA4, 0xB0, 0x99,
    0x92, 0x82, 0xF8, 0x80, 0x90
};

int main(void) {
    RCC->AHB1ENR |= (1U << 1);   // enable GPIOB clock
    GPIOB->MODER &= ~(0xFFFFU);  // clear PB0..PB7
    GPIOB->MODER |=  (0x5555U);  // PB0..PB7 as outputs

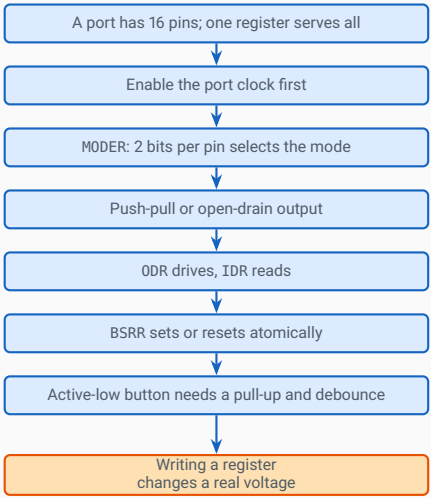
    uint8_t digit = 0;
    while (1) {
        GPIOB->ODR = seg7_ca[digit];  // already active-low
        digit = (digit + 1) % 10;
        delay_ms(1000);
    }
}
```

Why the values look inverted

Common-anode means the shared pin is tied to VDD; each segment lights when its own pin is pulled LOW. So the table is the bitwise complement of the familiar common-*cathode* codes: `0` is `0x3F` for a cathode display but `0xC0` here.

Because the table is already active-low, driving it is a single `ODR` write — no inversion in the loop.

Summary



Terminology covered

- Port, pin, `MODER`
- Push-pull, open-drain
- `ODR`, `IDR`, `BSRR`
- Pull-up, debouncing

Next: Chapter 9

Interrupts and Event-Driven Programming

Polling a button wastes the processor. Next, hardware tells us.

© Muním Zabidi

Table of Contents

1 Why This Matters

2 Inside a GPIO Pin

3 The GPIO Registers

4 Experiments

5 **Addendum**

Experiment 6: Knight Rider LED Chaser

```c
#include "stm32f4xx.h"
void delay_ms(uint32_t ms) { for (uint32_t i=0;i<ms*4000;i++) __NOP(); }

int main(void) {
    RCC->AHB1ENR |= (1U << 1);      // enable GPIOB clock
    GPIOB->MODER &= ~(0xFFFFU);     // clear PB0..PB7
    GPIOB->MODER |=  (0x5555U);     // PB0..PB7 as outputs (01 each)

    int pos = 0, dir = 1;
    while (1) {
        GPIOB->BSRR = (0xFFU << 16);   // all eight LEDs off
        GPIOB->BSRR = (1U << pos);     // light only the current one

        if (pos == 7 || pos == 0) dir = -dir;  // bounce at the ends
        pos += dir;

        delay_ms(80);
    }
}
```

One lit bit, walking back and forth

Only one output pin is ever high at a time; everything else is cleared first with a single atomic BSRR write, then the new bit is set with a second write. `pos` does the work a hardware shift register would do in an all-analogue version of this circuit — flipping `dir` at each end turns a shift into a bounce.

© Muním Zabidi